MESA C4 · AI AND ITS APPLICATIONS · PROBLEM STATEMENT 17 · THE 60-SECOND PITCH

Shreya spends four hours a week reading 60-plus articles, choosing eight to ten, and writing two or three lines on each. **The Dispatch** does the reading and the first draft: **Gemini Flash** collects, ranks, picks and drafts; **Shreya** reviews, edits and swaps in Telegram; only her explicit confirmation lets the email reach subscribers on Thursday morning. It never decides or sends on her behalf.

14+
live RSS feeds, plus 13 Google News searches and 3 news APIs (41 source jobs a run)

734
articles read this week, against the 60-plus a human shortlists from

10
stories picked across 7 topics (the brief asks for 8 to 10, 3+ topics)

2,200
active subscribers (a generated sample list); benchmark open rate 38%

Live app the-dispatch-ruby.vercel.app · /dashboard · /sample · /components-map · github.com/Roshan972003/the-dispatch · @Dispatch_Mesa_Bot

THE NINE CHECKS: DOES THE DISPATCH DESERVE TO BE BUILT? 9 OF 9 YES

Kill switches
Any No means: don't build it.

01 Problem real? YES ✓
Yes. Shreya spends 4 hours every week on reading 60-plus articles, choosing 8 to 10 and writing takes, for 2,200 subscribers who open at 38%.

02 Workflow repeated? YES ✓
Yes. Every Thursday for two years, in the same steps: collect, shortlist, write, assemble, send.

03 Input available? YES ✓
Yes. 14 live RSS feeds plus news APIs (41 source jobs a run), her voice as a style guide, past issues in the database, and the subscriber list.

Sizing
Any No means: build something smaller.

04 Output valuable? YES ✓
Yes. An issue of 10 curated stories with her take on each, in the email her readers already trust. A reader's time saved is hers to spend on reporting.

05 Impact measurable? YES ✓
Yes. Hours saved (4 h → a short review), repeats caught (80 this week), edits made, opens vs the 38% benchmark, unsubscribes and bounces. All on the dashboard.

08 ROI worth it? YES ✓
Yes. About 4 hours a week back, roughly 200 a year, on free-tier infrastructure (Vercel, Neon, Gemini Flash, Resend). The build is a one-off cost.

Boundary
Any No means: put a human exactly here.

06 Failure risk OK? YES ✓
Yes, because it is bounded. A bad pick or take is caught by rule checks and by her review; an email can't be un-sent, so sending needs her explicit confirmation.

07 Judgment protected? YES ✓
Yes. Her filters decide what counts; Gemini only proposes. She keeps, swaps, edits and confirms every story, so the editorial judgment stays hers.

09 Owner clear? YES ✓
Yes. Shreya owns the decision and the send. A 10 PM reminder exists so an unconfirmed issue never has an unclear owner.

LIVE SYSTEM CHECK TODAY, 9 OF 9 PASS: ✓ Neon · ✓ Telegram · ✓ Dashboard · ✓ Emails · ✓ GitHub · ✓ Vercel · ✓ Gemini Flash · ✓ Resend · ✓ News APIs and feeds

THE BRIEF, CLAUSE BY CLAUSE: WHAT WE BUILT, AND WHERE TO SHOW IT

Mon to Wed: ingest from multiple RSS feeds and news APIs
14 live RSS feeds, Google News searches, NewsAPI, GNews, NewsData, GDELT. Cron 08:00 IST.
DASHBOARD › SOURCES

No duplicates in the week, or vs the last four newsletters
URL hash, headline-similarity match, company/founder repeat guard.
OVERVIEW › FUNNEL

Wed pm: Gemini picks 8 to 10, high signal, 3+ topics
Scores every headline 0 to 100, shortlists 90, picks 10 across 7 topics; code checks every rule.
OVERVIEW › TOPICS

2 to 3 lines in Shreya's documented voice (style guide)
style_guide.md in a versioned table; rules enforced in code.
REVIEW › GUARDRAIL EDITOR

Draft to Telegram by Wed evening; review, edit, approve, swap
10 cards: Keep, Swap, Edit, Voice, Angles, one-tap rewrites.
TELEGRAM TAB + REAL BOT

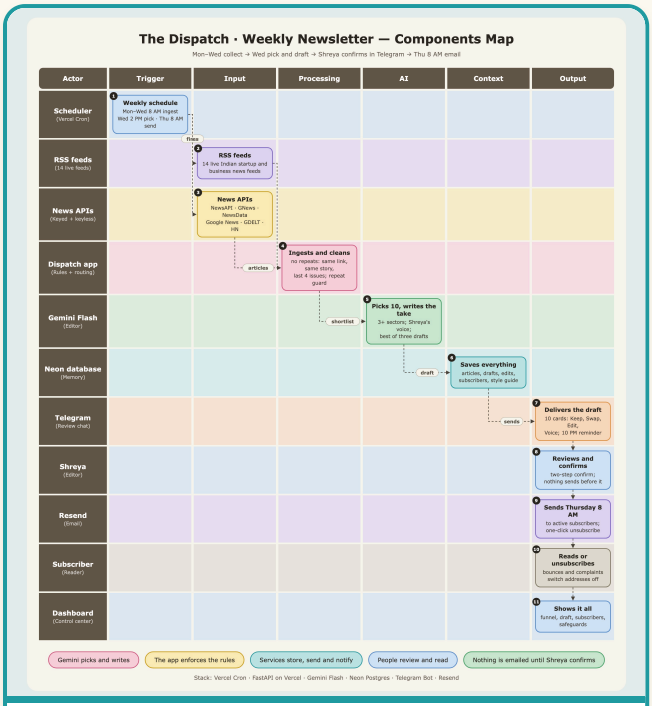
Never send autonomously; Thursday send on explicit confirmation
Two-step confirm; send_issue() refuses without approved_at; no send button on the dashboard.
EMAIL & SEND › LAUNCHPAD

No confirmation by Wed 10 PM: send a reminder
Cron 22:00 IST: pinned message with Confirm and Push-deadline buttons.
OVERVIEW › NEXT RUNS

Handle unsubscribes and bounces gracefully
One-click unsubscribe; hard bounces and complaints switch addresses off; friendly page for bad links.
SUBSCRIBERS TAB

All AI is Gemini Flash; not the Claude API
gemini.py is the only AI client (gemini-3.8-flash).
REPO: APP/GEMINI.PY

Live data; data at submission; deployed on Vercel
41 live source jobs; 734 articles and 2,200 subscribers stored; FastAPI on Vercel + Vercel Cron.
PUBLIC URL



The Components Map (a submission artefact)
Read it as a staircase: each lane is a component, each dashed arrow is what it hands on. Steps 1 to 11 are the order things happen.

THE WEEK, IN IST

Mon to Wed · 08:00	Ingest: fetch every source in parallel, store, remove repeats
Wed · 14:00	Gemini scores, shortlists, picks 10, drafts takes → draft lands in Telegram
Wed · 22:00	Reminder if unconfirmed (pinned, with buttons). Backup slots 23:00 Wed and 07:00 Thu run only if you snoozed
Thu · 08:00	Link check, then send, **only if confirmed**. If not: a "nothing was sent" warning
1st of month	Learn from Shreya's edits: add them as voice examples

Vercel's free Hobby plan runs each cron somewhere in the hour after its time, never earlier.

THE STACK

FASTAPI ON VERCEL · VERCEL CRON · GEMINI FLASH · NEON POSTGRES · TELEGRAM BOT API · RESEND · FEEDPARSER · HTTPX

DATABASE TABLES

`articles` `issues` `issue_items` `subscribers` `style_guide` `events` `email_events` `feeds` `kv`

WHERE EVERYTHING LIVES (REPO FOLDER DISPATCH/), IN ONE PHRASE EACH

`sources.py · ingest.py`
Fetch from RSS + APIs; store each article once; remove repeats
THE READER

`select_stories.py`
Score, shortlist, pick 10, draft takes, all the guards
THE EDITOR

`style_guide.md · styleguide.py`
Shreya's voice as rules and examples, versioned in the database
THE VOICE

`telegram.py`
Draft cards, every button, voice notes, confirm, reminder, group post
THE REVIEW DESK

`mailer.py · email_template.py`
Build the email; send in batches; bounces and unsubscribes
THE POSTMAN

`main.py · pipeline.py`
Web routes, secret-protected cron endpoints, webhooks; approval → send
THE SWITCHBOARD

`dashboard.py · dashboard_html.py`
Read-only control room: the API and the page
THE WINDOW

`linkcheck · access · readable`
Dead-link check, paywall detection, clean article text for Gemini
THE INSPECTORS

`gemini.py · db.py · config.py`
The only AI client; the database; settings from environment variables
THE PLUMBING

API KEYS AND SECRETS: WHAT EACH IS FOR (NAMES ONLY; VALUES STAY IN .ENV AND VERCEL)

GEMINI_API_KEY	Gemini Flash	Every AI task (score, pick, takes, angles, subjects, voice)
GEMINI_MODEL	Setting	Which model to call: gemini-3.8-flash
DATABASE_URL	Neon Postgres	Database: articles, issues, subscribers, style guide
NEWSAPI_KEY	NewsAPI.org	News search queries (7 per run)
GNEWS_API_KEY	GNews	Headline search (one call per run)
NEWSDATA_API_KEY	NewsData.io	News search (a few queries per run)
TELEGRAM_BOT_TOKEN	Telegram Bot API	Send and edit messages as @Dispatch_Mesa_Bot
TELEGRAM_CHAT_ID	Telegram	Shreya's chat: the only chat the bot obeys
TELEGRAM_WEBHOOK_SECRET	Telegram	Proves a webhook call is from Telegram
RESEND_API_KEY	Resend	Sends the newsletter (a send-only key)
RESEND_FROM	Resend	Sender address (Resend test sender for now)
RESEND_WEBHOOK_SECRET	Resend	Verifies bounce, complaint, open webhooks
CRON_SECRET	Vercel Cron	Locks the scheduled-job endpoints
PUBLIC_URL	Setting	Base address for links inside emails

No key needed for Google News searches, Hacker News and GDELT. Rotate keys after submission.

RSS FEEDS IN USE (14 LIVE OF 20 REGISTERED)

Inc42 · inc42.com · YourStory · yourstory.com · Economic Times Startups · economictimes.indiatimes.com · Economic Times Tech · economictimes.indiatimes.com · TechCrunch · techcrunch.com · Medianama · medianama.com · The Hindu BusinessLine Startups · thehindubusinessline.com · Livemint Companies · livemint.com · Livemint Technology · livemint.com · The Ken · the-ken.com · Entrackr · entrackr.com · The Arc · thearcweb.com · Indian Express Tech · indianexpress.com · Rest of World · restofworld.org

SWITCHED OFF (6): ERRORS OR NO RECENT ITEMS

~~Moneycontrol Startups~~ · ~~Business Standard Startups~~ · ~~VCCircle~~ · ~~Analytics India Magazine~~ · ~~Tracxn Blog~~ · ~~Entrackr (old /feed address)~~

OTHER SOURCES, PER RUN

13 Google News searches (e.g. India startup funding · layoffs · shutdown) · **NewsAPI** 7 queries (funding, layoffs, SEBI IPO, fintech/RBI, D2C, AI, SaaS) · **GNews** · **NewsData** · **GDELT** · **Hacker News**. In total 41 source jobs a run.

3 How the AI decides, and why it is safe

Nine small, checkable steps: Gemini proposes, code verifies, Shreya decides

1 Collect

Fetches RSS feeds, Google News searches, GDELT, Hacker News, NewsAPI, GNews and NewsData in parallel. A source that fails is skipped and shown; the rest carry on.

2 Remove repeats

Each article is stored once by link. Near-identical headlines are matched within the week and against the last four issues. Marked duplicate, never deleted.

3 Pre-screen

Gemini scores every unique headline 0 to 100 on Shreya's three filters: counterintuitive, under-reported, trend-connecting. 10 parallel chunks.

4 Shortlist

The top 90 by score, at most 14 per source so one outlet can't dominate. Anything added by hand with /add is always in.

5 Pick 10

Gemini chooses 8 to 10 (target 10), none from the last four issues, across 3+ topics. Code re-checks count, topics, ids; retry, then repair.

6 Guards

Entity check: a company or founder covered in the last four issues is swapped for the next best. A hard-paywalled pick is swapped for a free one.

7 Write the take

Three drafts a story, a Gemini judge picks the best, code checks the rules. Four runner-ups are pre-drafted so Swap is instant.

8 Extras

Counter-arguments for each story, three subject lines, trend-connection ideas between stories.

9 Deliver

10 Telegram cards, a subject chooser and a Confirm button. Nothing is emailed until Shreya confirms.

EVERY RULE A TAKE MUST PASS (CHECKED IN CODE)

- 2 to 3 sentences, 65 words at most
- No banned phrases, no "!", no emoji
- Must not just repeat the headline
- Every number and name must appear in the source article (no invented facts)
- Ends on something the reader can watch for

WHY IT CAN'T GO WRONG

- **Never sends alone**: Telegram two-step confirm; send_issue() refuses without approved_at; the Thursday job checks status
- **Only Shreya's chat** is obeyed (chat id + webhook secret)
- **Cron routes** need a secret; Resend and Telegram webhooks are verified
- **Link check** before the Thursday send
- Secrets only in environment variables

WHERE GEMINI FLASH IS USED (ONLY GEMINI)

SCORING HEADLINES · PICKING THE ISSUE · WRITING + JUDGING TAKES · COUNTER-ARGUMENTS · SUBJECT LINES · TREND FUSION · VOICE NOTE → TAKE · ANSWERING STORY QUESTIONS · SPICIER / UNIT ECON. / TRIM · MONTHLY VOICE LEARNING

Gemini proposes. Plain code then verifies every rule. The human decides.

WHAT IF SOMETHING FAILS?

A news source is down
Skipped and listed under "failed on the last run"; every other source carries on.

Gemini's pick breaks a rule
Validate → retry → repair; any remaining issue is flagged ⚠ at the top of the draft.

A take breaks a voice rule
⚠ Auto-check on that card; fix it with a rewrite button.

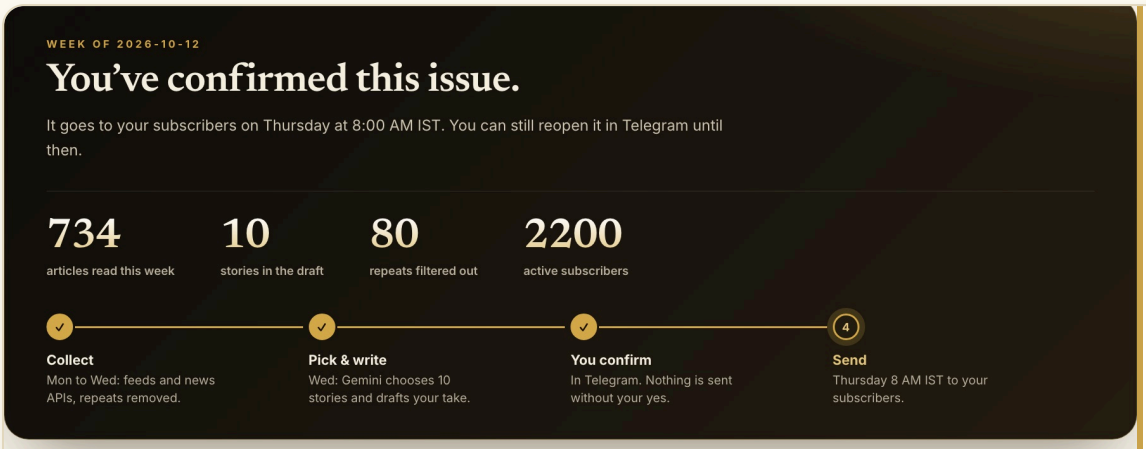
A link is dead on Thursday
The link check tells you in Telegram; the issue still goes out as confirmed.

Some emails fail to send
Temporary failures retried; the send log counts sent, retried, failed.

She never confirms
10 PM reminder; Thursday 8 AM "not confirmed, nothing sent". Nothing is emailed.

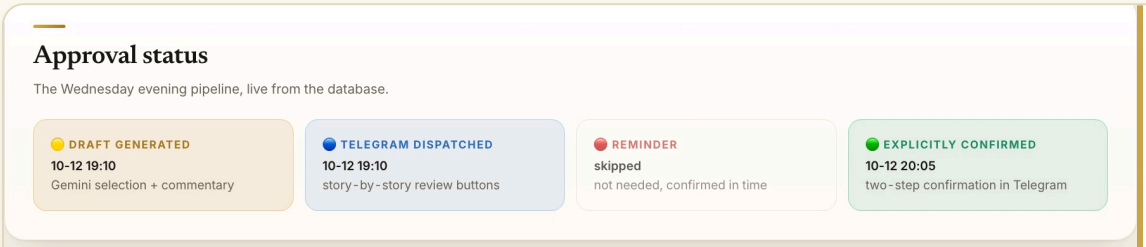
> *If asked "what is the AI actually doing?": "It does the volume work: reading 700 articles, scoring them, drafting ten takes. A second layer of plain code verifies every rule, and the human decides."*

*Open **/dashboard**. It is public so anyone can see it; it can preview and run safe steps but can **never approve or send**. Tabs: Overview · Review the draft · Insights · Telegram · Email & send · Subscribers · All articles · Sources. ⌘K opens a command palette; ◐ toggles light/dark.*



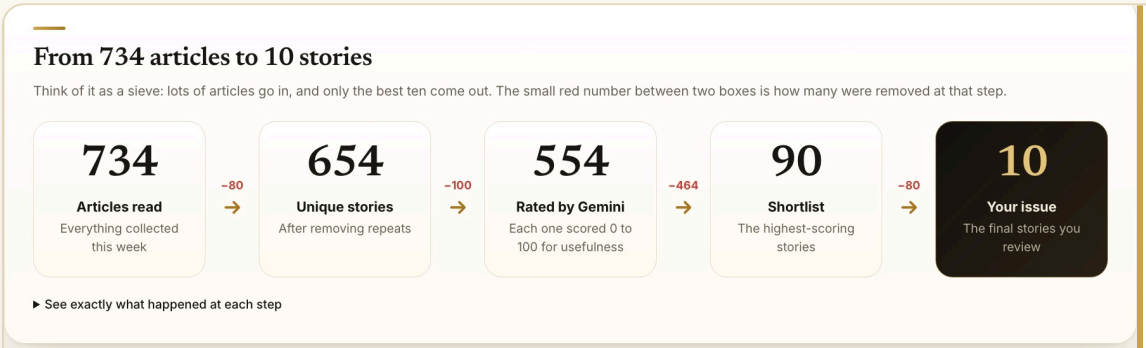
① Status hero · ② four live numbers · ③ stage tracker

The hero sentence follows the real state (collecting → draft ready → confirmed → sent). Numbers: articles read, stories in the draft, repeats removed, active subscribers. The gold line is the 4-stage tracker.



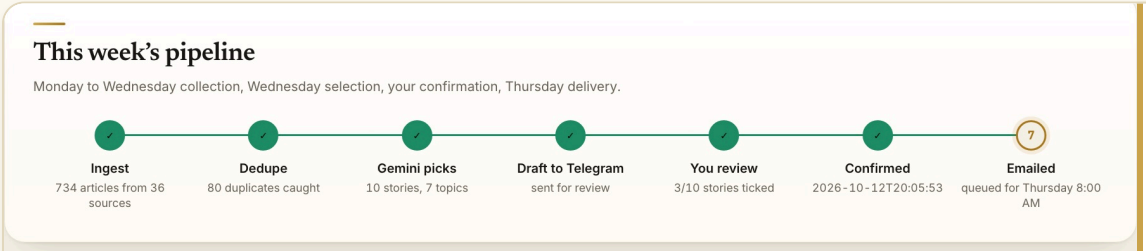
④ Approval status, colour-coded

🟡 Draft generated · 🔵 Telegram dispatched · 🔴 Reminder (skipped if you confirm in time) · 🟢 Explicitly confirmed, each with its real timestamp.



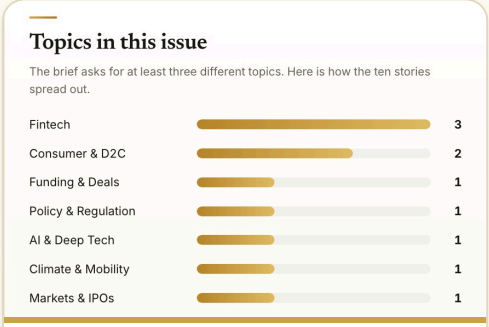
⑤ "From 734 articles to 10 stories": the funnel

734 collected → 654 unique (80 repeats removed) → 554 scored by Gemini → 90 shortlisted → 10 in the issue. The small red number between boxes is how many were removed at that step; the foldout lists the exact reasons.



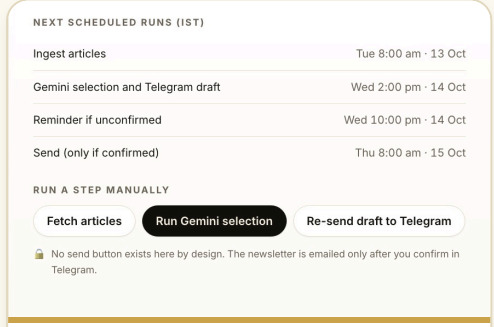
⑥ Pipeline steps

Seven real events: Ingest · Dedupe · Gemini picks · Draft to Telegram · You review · Confirmed · Emailed. Below it (not shown): KPI tiles for articles, duplicates, sources live 36/41, scored, average signal of the picks, subscribers.



⑦ Topics in this issue

Seven topics; the brief's two rules ticked (8 to 10 stories, 3+ topics).



⑧ Next runs · run a step

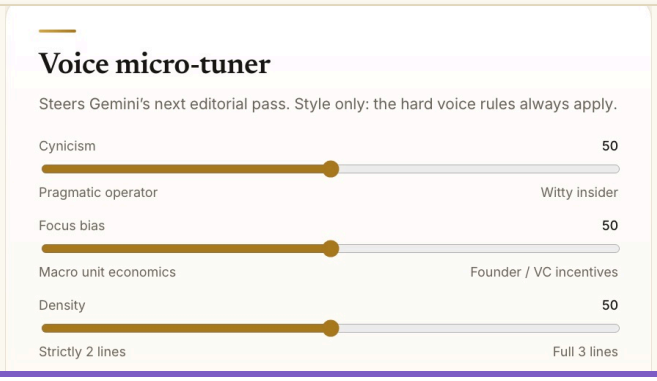
The real crons in IST. "Run a step manually" has **no Send button**, by design.



⑨ Activity log

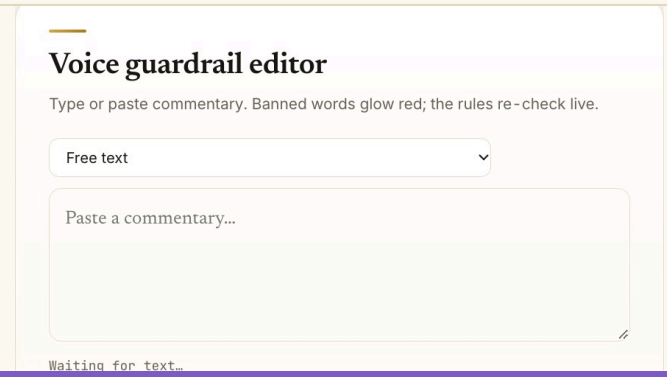
The audit trail: every pick, draft, tune, swap, confirmation and ingest.

REVIEW THE DRAFT (PREVIEW TOOLS: REAL EDITS ARE MADE IN TELEGRAM)



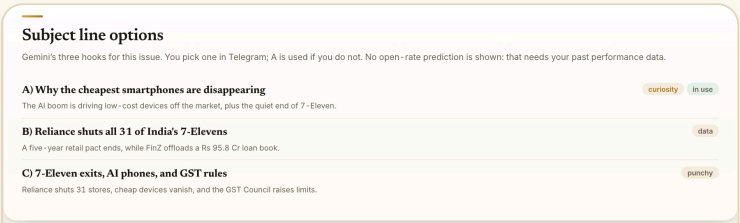
① Voice micro-tuner

Three sliders (cynicism, focus, density) steer the *next* Gemini pass. Saved, but they don't rewrite the current draft.



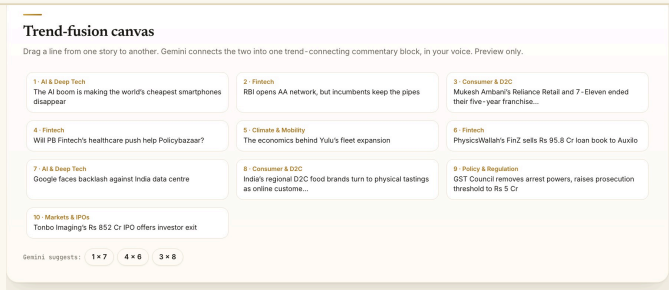
② Voice guardrail editor

A practice box: paste any text and banned words glow red while the rules re-check live. Saves nothing.



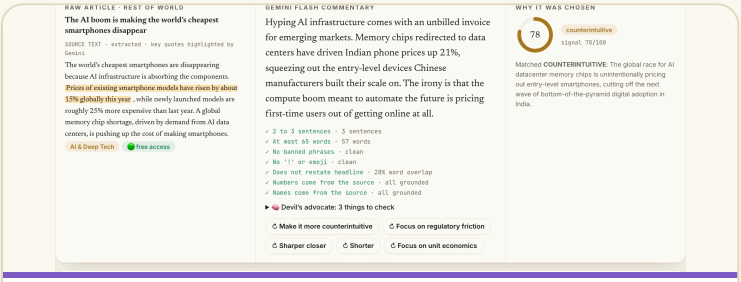
③ Subject line options

Gemini's three hooks with their preheaders; the pick is made in Telegram.



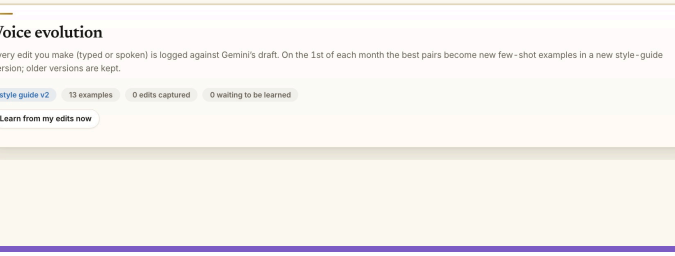
④ Trend-fusion canvas

"Connect two trends nobody has linked." Drag a line between two stories; Gemini writes one connecting block. Preview only.



⑤ Reasoning cards (one per story)

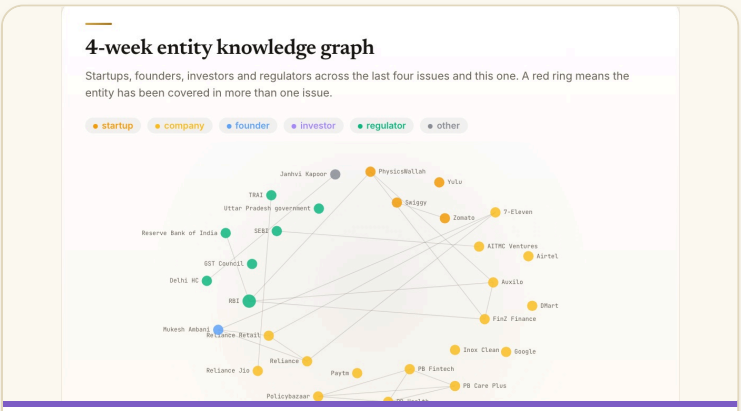
Raw article · Gemini's take with rewrite chips · signal ring, rule checks ✓/✗ and why it was picked, with counter-arguments.



⑥ Voice evolution · runner-ups drawer

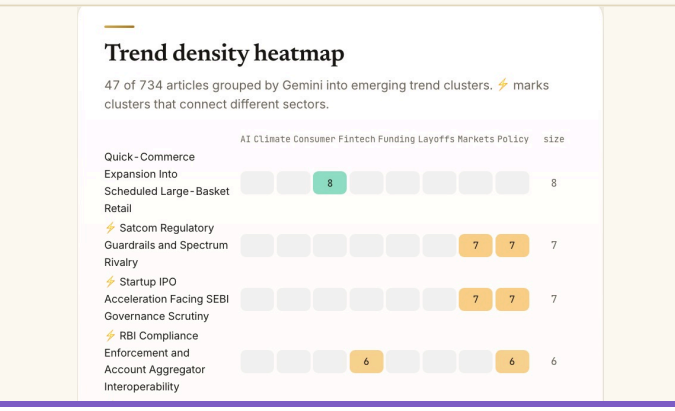
Every edit is logged vs Gemini's draft; on the 1st of the month "Learn from my edits" turns them into style-guide examples. The drawer holds the 4 pre-drafted backups.

INSIGHTS (THE "MEMORY" OF THE LAST FOUR ISSUES)



⑦ Four-week entity graph

Startups, founders, investors, regulators named across the last four issues and this one. A name already in an earlier issue is how the repeat guard sees "covered".



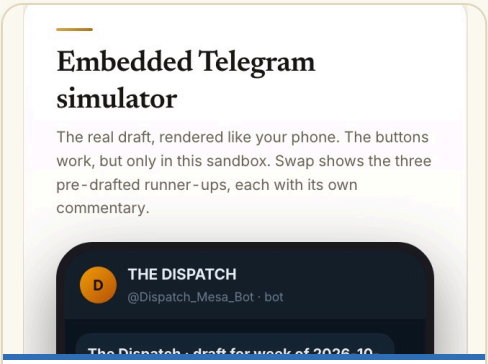
⑧ Trend heatmap · ⑨ Archive matrix

Gemini groups articles into trend clusters across sectors (⚡ = a trend crossing sectors). The matrix counts stories per sector per issue: what new picks are checked against.

> *Say: "The dashboard **previews**; Telegram **changes**. That separation is why the dashboard can be open to anyone."*

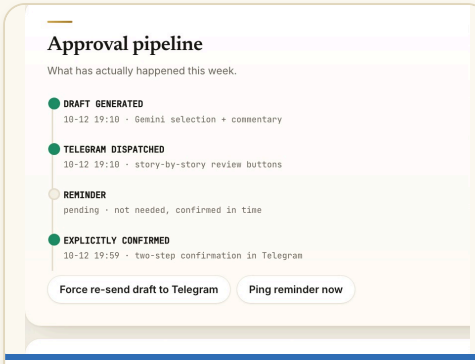
Dashboard · Tabs 4 to 8

Telegram, Email & send, Subscribers, All articles, Sources: real snippets



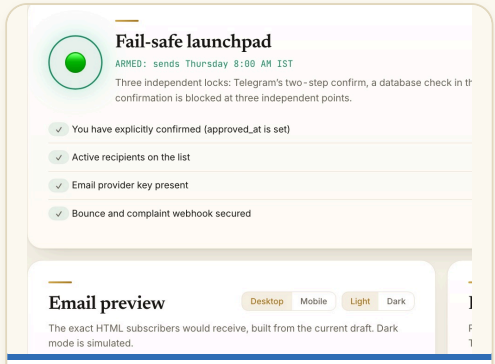
① Telegram tab: phone simulator

Your real draft rendered like the phone, with working buttons. **Sandbox only**: it never changes your real draft.



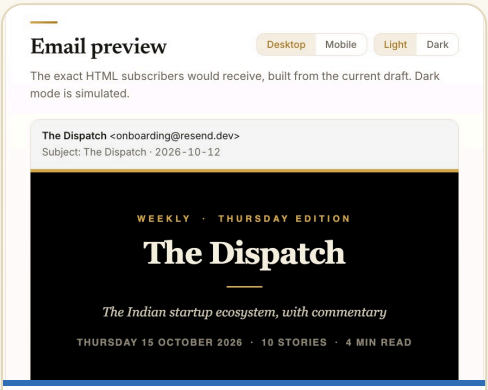
② Approval timeline

What has really happened this week, plus why approval stays in Telegram: two-step confirm, only your chat obeyed.



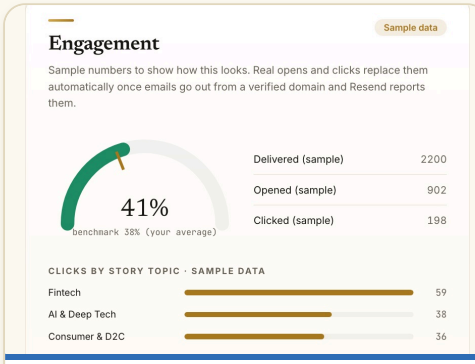
③ Email & send: fail-safe launchpad

The safety interlock: lamp (safe/armed) and a checklist incl. “you have explicitly confirmed”. Sending can only start from Telegram.



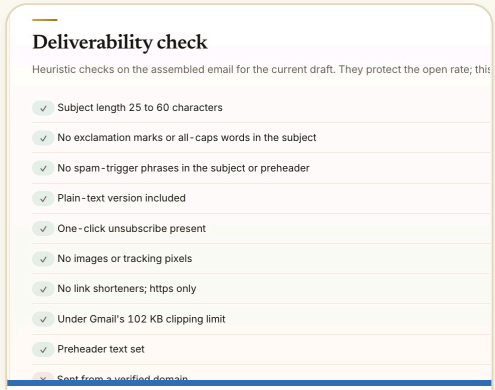
④ Email preview

The exact HTML subscribers get; Desktop/Mobile and Light/Dark switches.



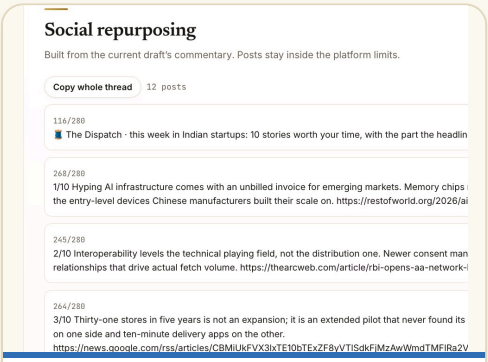
⑤ Link health · engagement

Link health pings every link (counts only for the current draft). Engagement is **labelled sample data** until real Resend events arrive.



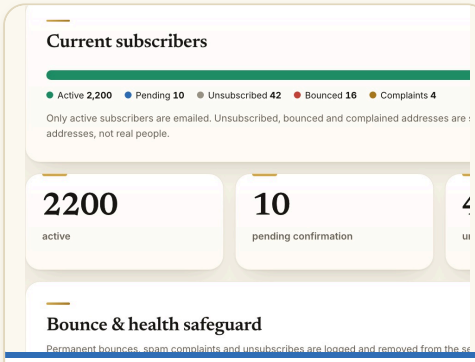
⑥ Deliverability check

Ten spam-risk checks; nine pass, “verified sending domain” fails until a domain is set up. Honest.



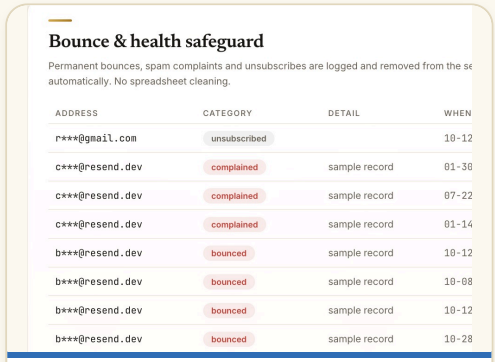
⑦ Social repurposing · outreach list

One-click X thread (each post ≤ 280) and LinkedIn post; search links to tag featured startups, founders, investors.



⑧ Subscribers: current

2,200 active will get the next issue; the bar splits active / pending / unsubscribed / bounced / complaints.



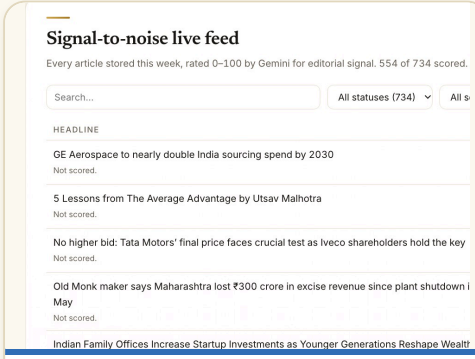
⑨ Bounce & health safeguard

Every hard bounce, complaint and unsubscribe is logged and switched off automatically. Also: reasons, add subscribers, send log.



⑩ Sources

Last ingest: 36 of 41 source jobs responded; lists feeds, searches, API queries and a “failed on the last run” box.



⑪ All articles

Every article with status, signal score and **the reason** it was kept or dropped. Search, filter, Show more.

IF THE EXAMINER CLICKS AROUND

- **Remind me now / Snooze 30m / 1h** (top banner): pings you in Telegram / moves the 10 PM deadline.
- **Re-send draft to Telegram**: regenerates the draft; **the old Telegram cards stop working**. Avoid before submission.
- **Run Gemini selection**: redoes the whole pick (about 2 min). **Fetch articles**: pulls new ones.
- **⌘K** jumps to any tab or step; ◐ toggles light/dark.

ONE STORY CARD, AS SHREYA SEES IT

2/10 · Fintech · *under-reported* · ✏️ edited
RBI opens AA network, but incumbents keep the pipes (The Arc)
🟢 free access

Interoperability breaks the technical lock-in for newer entrants, but it cannot deliver distribution. Incumbent aggregators still hold the deep integrations with banks where customer consent converts into volume.

⚠️ *Auto-check: (only if a rule fails)*

[✅ Keep] [🔁 Swap] [✏️ Edit]
[🎙 Voice] [🧠 Angles]
[🔥 Spicier] [📊 Unit econ.] [✂️ Trim]

Italic label = why Gemini picked it: **counterintuitive**, **under-reported** or **trend-connecting**. Taps change the card **in place**.

THE CONFIRMATION JOURNEY

The Dispatch · draft for week of 2026-10-12
10 stories · 2200 active subscribers
Nothing is sent until you confirm.

Send this issue to **2200** subscribers on Thursday morning? This is the final confirmation.
[✅ Yes, send Thursday] [Cancel]

✅ **Confirmed.** It will go out Thursday 15 Oct, 8:00 AM IST.
[↩️ Reopen draft]

🚨 **The Dispatch is waiting on you.** (Wed 10 PM, pinned)
[✅ Confirm & schedule 8 AM]
[⏭ Push deadline to Thu 7 AM]

📰 **The Dispatch · Edition of Thursday 15 October 2026** (posted in the group when you confirm, then each story with your take)

COLOUR AND SYMBOL CODE

🟢	**free access**	Opens normally
🟡	**soft paywall**	Meter or sign-up wall; usually readable
🔴	**hard paywall**	Subscription needed; swapped for a free runner-up when one exists
🔴	**link looks dead**	The link fails to load
✅	**before the title**	You tapped Keep: reviewed
✏️	**edited**	You changed the take
⚠️	**Auto-check**	A voice rule failed; fix with a rewrite button
⏳	**grey line**	Gemini is working; card updates in place
🎙	**Heard**	What it heard from your voice note
🧠	**Angles**	Counter-arguments: things to check, not facts
🔗	**Connect it to**	Other stories this links to
💬	**You asked**	Your question and the answer
📌	**waiting on you**	The 10 PM reminder (pinned)

Dashboard approval timeline: 🟡 draft generated · 🔵 Telegram dispatched · 🔴 reminder · 🟢 confirmed

WHAT EVERY BUTTON DOES

✅ Keep	Ticks the story as reviewed (✅ in front); the final confirmation counts how many are not yet ticked
🔁 Swap	Shows the 3 pre-drafted runner-ups, each with its own take; pick one and the card changes in place; Back returns
✏️ Edit	Reply to the card with your version; it replaces the take and is logged for monthly voice learning
🎙 Voice	Reply with a voice note; Gemini turns your raw words into 2 to 3 lines in your voice (about 15 s)
🧠 Angles	Counter-arguments and links to other stories; tap again to hide
🔥 Spicier	One-tap rewrite: sharper claim, a dry edge, still inside the hard rules
📊 Unit economics	Rewrite with the unit-economics angle, using only numbers the article states
✂️ Trim to 2 lines	Rewrite to exactly two sentences, keeping the sharpest claim and the closer
↩️ Back to original	Appears after a change; restores Gemini's first draft
📮 Confirm final draft	Asks "Send to N subscribers Thursday?" → ✅ Yes, send Thursday / Cancel → "Confirmed" + ↩️ Reopen. Confirmed after Thursday 08:00 = sent immediately

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER A TAP

Keep / Swap / Angles instant, no Gemini call
TAP → CARD CHANGES IN PLACE

Spicier / Unit economics / Trim about 8 seconds
TAP → ⏳ GREY LINE → GEMINI REWRITES → RULE CHECK → CARD UPDATES

Edit your words
TAP EDIT → REPLY TO THE CARD → TAKE REPLACED → LOGGED FOR LEARNING

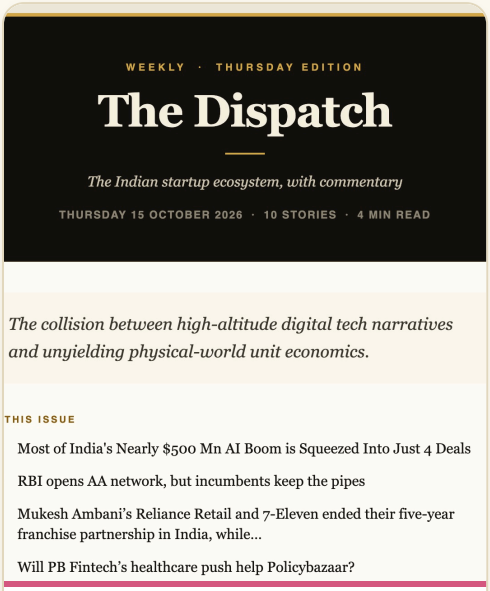
Voice about 15 seconds
TAP VOICE → REPLY WITH A VOICE NOTE → GEMINI LISTENS → 2 TO 3 LINES IN YOUR VOICE

Confirm two steps, then Thursday
CONFIRM FINAL DRAFT → YES, SEND THURSDAY → CONFIRMED → GROUP POST → THU 08:00 SEND

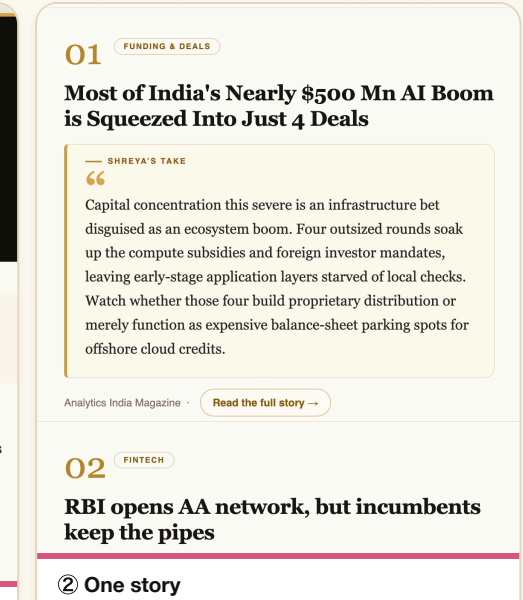
COMMANDS AND REPLIES

- `/add <link>` hand-picks an article into the pool (always shortlisted)
- Reply to a card with text (not in Edit mode) to **ask a question about that story**
- `/setgroup@Dispatch_Mesa_Bot` in "Shreya and THE DISPATCH": each confirmed final draft is also posted there with its date

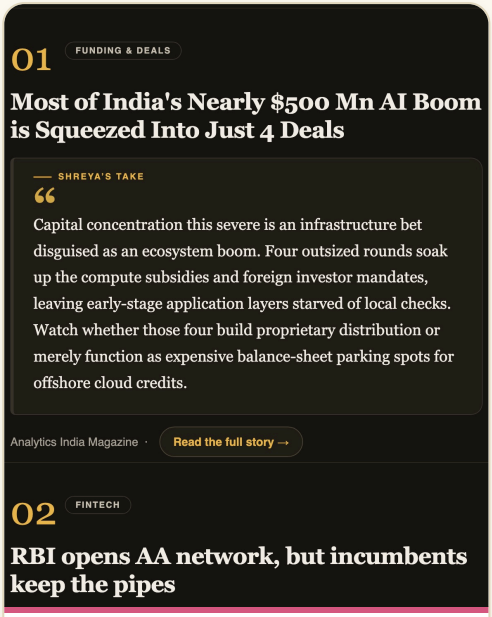
One template renders every email. No images or tracking pixels (loads instantly, avoids spam filters), a plain-text twin, one-click unsubscribe, dark mode and a phone layout. Every story links to the original article.



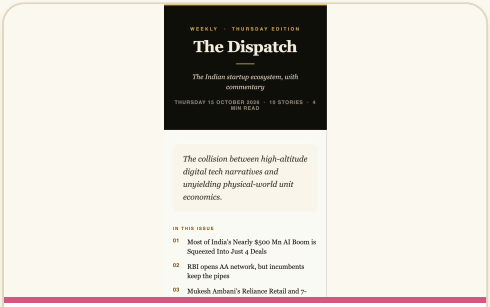
① The standard issue, top
Dark masthead with gold trim, date · story count · read time, Shreya's one-line theme, "In this issue".



② One story
Numeral, topic pill, headline, **Shreya's take** in a cream panel, source and a "Read the full story" button.



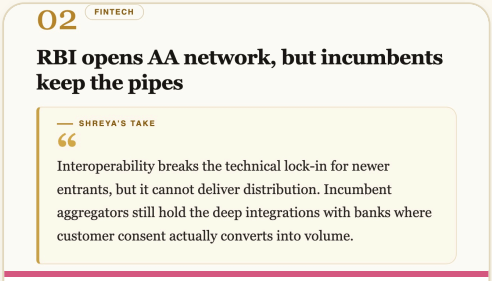
③ Dark mode
Automatic for readers whose email app is dark.



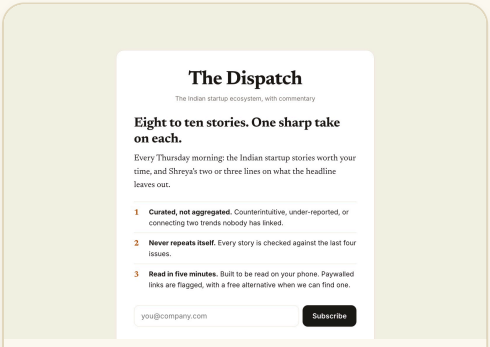
④ On a phone (390 px)
Single column, larger text.



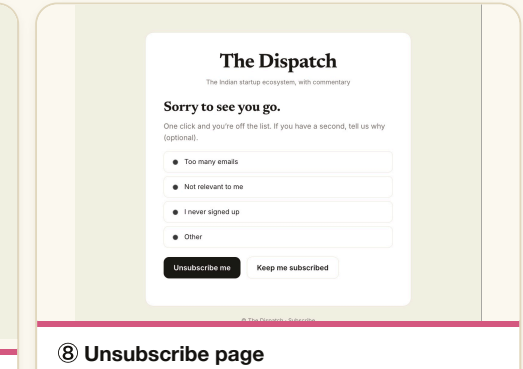
⑤ Soft-paywall story
🔒 line, plus a **free coverage** link when one is found.



⑥ Hard-paywall story
Honest wording: "Subscription needed… the take above stands on its own."



⑦ Subscribe page (/)
Where a reader joins; the sample issue is one click away.



⑧ Unsubscribe page
One click, optional reason, resubscribe link. Any bad or old link ends on a friendly page, never an error.

⑨ THE PLAIN-TEXT VERSION

```
THE DISPATCH · Thursday 15 October 2026
The Indian startup ecosystem, with commentary

The collision between high-altitude digital
tech narratives and unyielding physical-world
unit economics.

IN THIS ISSUE
1. Most of India's Nearly $500 Mn AI Boom is
Squeezed Into Just 4 Deals
2. RBI opens AA network, but incumbents keep
the pipes
3. Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Retail and 7-
Eleven ended their five-year franchise
partnership in India, while Reliance shut all
31 remaining 7-Eleven stores, bringing the
convenience...
```

WHEN AND TO WHOM IT IS SENT

- Thursday 08:00 IST, **only if Shreya confirmed**; confirmed after 08:00 = sent immediately.
- Only **active** subscribers; unsubscribed, bounced and complaint addresses are skipped.
- Sent in batches via Resend; temporary failures are retried and counted; a link check runs first.
- Sample addresses are capped at 25 per send.

BOUNCES AND UNSUBSCRIBES (RESEND WEBHOOK)

- **Hard bounce** (address doesn't exist): switched off.
- **Spam complaint**: switched off.
- **Temporary bounce** (full inbox): stays active.
- **Unsubscribe**: switched off; can resubscribe.

The brief says "unsubscribes from Gmail bounces": we handle unsubscribes and bounces reported by the email provider. Reading bounce replies from a Gmail inbox is not built.

9 Viva: demo route, questions and honest limits

What to do, what to say, and what to admit

FINAL PAGE

A 5-MINUTE DEMO ROUTE

0:00 — **Components Map**
"Nine components; Gemini only proposes, the human decides."

0:45 — **Overview: hero, funnel**
"Hundreds in, ten out, every drop has a reason."

1:45 — **A reasoning card**
"Raw article, take, why picked, counter-arguments."

2:30 — **Phone: tap Spicier**
"Card changes in place; Confirm is two taps."

3:30 — **/sample + launchpad**
"Exactly what subscribers get; send needs her yes."

4:15 — **Bounce safeguard, unsubscribe**
"A bad link never shows an error."

LIKELY QUESTIONS, AND YOUR ANSWERS

Why approve in Telegram, not the dashboard?

The dashboard is open to anyone, so it can only preview. Approval needs Shreya's own chat, the only chat the bot obeys.

Show: Dashboard › Telegram › "Why approval stays in Telegram"

How do you guarantee it never sends alone?

Three locks: Telegram's two-step confirm; send_issue() refuses without approved_at; the Thursday job checks status. No send button on the dashboard.

Show: Email & send › Fail-safe launchpad

How are duplicates prevented?

Same link = same article. Near-identical headlines are matched within the week and vs the last four issues; a repeat guard catches a new story on a covered company. Duplicates are marked, not deleted.

Show: Overview funnel; All articles (reason column)

How does Gemini pick 'high signal'?

It scores every headline 0 to 100 on her three filters vs this week's batch, then picks from the top 90. Code re-checks count, topics and ids.

Show: Review the draft › a reasoning card (signal ring)

How do you stop made-up facts?

Every number and proper name in a take must appear in the source article (checked in code). Counter-arguments are labelled 'things to check, not facts'.

Show: A reasoning card's rule checks (✓/✗)

What is the 'documented voice'?

style_guide.md: filters, banned phrases, hard rules and examples, stored as a versioned table; her edits are promoted into it monthly.

Show: Repo: style_guide.md; Voice evolution card

What if Gemini returns something bad?

Selection: validate → retry → repair. Takes: best of three, judged, rule-checked; failures get a ⚠ flag. Failed sources are skipped and shown.

Show: Sources › "failed on the last run"

What if she never confirms?

10 PM reminder; Thursday 8 AM 'not confirmed, nothing sent'. Nothing goes out.

Show: Overview › Next scheduled runs

Is the 2,200 list real?

A generated sample, tagged sample; real subscribers import with scripts/import_subscribers.py; sample sends are capped at 25.

Show: Subscribers tab

Why do engagement numbers say 'sample'?

Opens and clicks come from Resend webhooks after real sends from a verified domain; until then the panel is labelled sample.

Show: Email & send › Engagement

Why Gemini Flash for everything?

The brief requires it. Flash is fast and cheap enough to score about 700 headlines a week; the one-tap buttons use a low-latency mode (about 8 s).

Show: Repo: app/gemini.py

What happens on Thursday morning, exactly?

08:00 IST: link check, then, only if confirmed, a batch send to active subscribers. If not confirmed: a 'nothing was sent' message.

Show: Overview › Next scheduled runs

BE HONEST ABOUT THESE

- **Sample data**: 2,200 list and engagement are labelled sample
- **Sending domain**: test sender reaches only the account owner
- **Cron timing**: free Vercel plan runs within the hour after
- **RSS**: 14 of 20 registered feeds are active (6 block bots)
- **GDELT** often refuses Vercel; skipped with a message
- **Story 3** has a very long headline; consider swapping it

NUMBERS TO KNOW (12 OCT)

734 collected · **654** unique (80 repeats)
554 scored · **90** shortlisted · **10** picked, **7** topics
36 of 41 source jobs · **14** live RSS feeds
2,200 active subscribers (sample)
Pipeline run: about **125 to 175 s** (limit 300 s)

BEFORE YOU WALK IN

- Open /dashboard (Cmd+Shift+R), /sample, /components-map, Telegram
- If the hero says **"You've confirmed this issue"**, the email really goes Thursday 8 AM (test sender: only the account owner receives it). Tap ↩ Reopen to stop it
- Don't press Re-send draft or Run selection live

> ***End with:*** *"The system does the four hours of reading and drafting; Shreya keeps the two minutes of judgment, and nothing reaches a subscriber without her explicit yes."*

Glossary and the voice file

Plain-English terms, and what Shreya's style guide contains

GLOSSARY: THE WORDS YOU MAY BE ASKED ABOUT, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Cron
A timer that runs a job at a set time (Vercel Cron here)

RSS feed
A site's list of its latest articles, readable by programs

News API
A service you ask for articles on a topic (NewsAPI, GNews, NewsData)

Webhook
A service calling *us* when something happens: a Telegram tap, an email bounce

Endpoint
A web address that runs one job when called, e.g. /api/cron/send

Serverless
Code that runs only when called; no server is kept switched on

Dedupe
Spotting the same story twice: same link, or a near-identical headline

Repeat guard
Swaps a story about a company or founder covered in the last four issues

Signal score
Gemini's 0 to 100 rating of how worth featuring a story is

Shortlist
The top 90 stories by score that go forward to the final pick

Prompt
The written instructions given to Gemini for one task

Few-shot example
A worked example inside the prompt that shows Gemini the target voice

Style guide
Shreya's voice as rules, banned phrases and examples, stored and versioned

Guardrail
A rule checked in code (not just asked in the prompt), e.g. 65 words max

Hallucination
An AI inventing a fact; blocked by checking numbers and names against the source

Paywall (soft / hard)
Soft: a sign-up or meter wall. Hard: subscription needed to read at all

Preheader
The grey preview line next to the subject in an inbox

Hard / soft bounce
Hard: address doesn't exist, switch off. Soft: full inbox, keep active

Spam complaint
A reader marks the email as spam; that address is switched off

Deliverability
How likely the email is to reach the inbox, not spam

Bearer token
A secret sent with a request to prove it is allowed (locks the cron endpoints)

Idempotent
Doing it twice gives the same result as once (Telegram updates run once)

Inline keyboard
The buttons attached under a Telegram message

UTC vs IST
Cron uses UTC; India time (IST) is UTC + 5:30, so 02:30 UTC = 08:00 IST

Postgres / Neon
The database that stores everything; Neon hosts it online

SaaS-able
Could be sold as a product to many newsletters, not just this one

THE VOICE FILE (STYLE_GUIDE.MD): WHAT IS INSIDE IT

WHAT IT HOLDS

- **Philosophy:** she doesn't aggregate; the value is selection and second-order commentary
- **3 selection filters:** counterintuitive, under-reported, trend-connecting (a story must pass one)
- **Structure of a take:** claim → one mechanism → a testable closer
- **Hard rules:** 2 to 3 sentences, 65 words max, never restate the headline, only facts from the article, no emoji, no "!"
- **13 worked examples** and the prompts for selection and drafting
- **Learning:** her edits are saved and promoted monthly; every change is a new version, so old issues stay reproducible

THE 9 CRAFT TECHNIQUES

1. Incentives before adjectives
2. Mechanism over opinion
3. Say what it changes or signals
4. Name the lazy reading, then correct it
5. One specific beats three general
6. Commit: take a position
7. Dry, never mean
8. Rhythm: active verbs, short after long
9. The closer is testable

Added so each take reads like the best newsletter writers: technique, never copied wording.

BANNED PHRASES

~~game-changer~~ ~~revolutionary~~ ~~landscape~~ ~~deep dive~~ ~~paradigm shift~~ ~~soaring~~ ~~testament to~~ ~~unprecedented~~ ~~disrupt~~ ~~cutting-edge~~ ~~in today's fast-paced world~~ ~~unlock~~ ~~seamless~~ ~~exciting~~ ~~poised to~~ ~~a win for~~

A REAL EXAMPLE (EXAMPLE 1, UNDER-REPORTED)

Headline: Quick-commerce firm adds 300 dark stores across Tier-2 cities
Take: Store count is the easy number to announce. The hard one is order density: a Tier-2 dark store needs a metro-sized daily order volume from far fewer households. Watch delivery fees and minimum basket sizes, because they will show whether the economics work.

11 How it was tested, and how to run it

Evidence for the viva, local setup, secrets and deployment

REFERENCE

HOW IT WAS TESTED (WHAT YOU CAN SAY YOU VERIFIED)

Never sends unconfirmed
Tried to send in 3 states (drafted, approved without confirmation, collecting): refused every time

Duplicates
A near-identical headline is caught; an unrelated one is not

Hard bounce / complaint
Address switched off; a soft bounce leaves it active

Unsubscribe
Works by token; an unknown token ends on a friendly page, no error

Brief timing
Crons mapped to 08:00 IST Mon–Wed, 14:00 Wed, 22:00 Wed, 08:00 Thu

Gemini only
No Claude or OpenAI client in the code; a live Gemini call answers in about 2 s

Screens
8 tabs × 4 widths (1440, 1024, 768, 390): no overlap, clipping or sideways scroll

Buttons
18 interactive checks pass (preview toggles, palette, search, drawer, voice checker, simulator)

Links
16 links in the email and 11 site pages all return 200, bad tokens included

Final audit
24 of 24 live checks: Neon, Telegram, Vercel crons locked (401), webhooks reject unsigned (403)

RUN IT LOCALLY

```
python3 -m venv venv
./venv/bin/pip install -r requirements.txt
cp .env.example .env # fill in the keys
./venv/bin/uvicorn app.main:app --port 8000
./venv/bin/python scripts/poll.py # drive Telegram locally
```

- With no DATABASE_URL it uses a local SQLite file
- `scripts/import_subscribers.py` imports Shreya's real list
- `scripts/seed_sample_2200.py` makes the demo list
- `scripts/migrate_to_neon.py` moves data to Neon

HOW IT WAS DEPLOYED, STEP BY STEP

1. Code written in the `dispatch/` folder and pushed to GitHub (public repo)
2. Neon project created; `DATABASE_URL` added; data migrated with `migrate_to_neon.py`
3. Vercel project connected to the GitHub repo; every push to `main` deploys
4. Environment variables added in Vercel (Gemini, Telegram, Resend, news APIs, secrets)
5. Telegram webhook pointed at `/api/telegram/webhook` with a secret
6. Cron schedules read from `vercel.json`; each endpoint needs the cron secret
7. Resend webhook added for bounces and complaints; Vercel login protection turned off so the public URL opens

SECRETS, GITHUB AND DEPLOYMENT

- **README.md** in the repo: live links, weekly flow, brief-to-code table, safeguards, setup and honest limits
- **No secrets in GitHub:** keys live in `.env` (git-ignored) and Vercel environment variables; only `.env.example` (names, no values) is committed
- **Deploy:** push to `main` and Vercel builds automatically; crons are defined in `vercel.json`
- **After submission:** rotate the keys that were shared during building (Gemini, Telegram, Neon, Resend, news APIs)
- **Commits** use the GitHub no-reply address, not a school email

URL CHEAT SHEET

`/`	Subscribe page (public)
`/dashboard`	Control room (open, preview-only)
`/sample`	The current issue as subscribers see it
`/components-map`	The Components Map
`/unsubscribe?t=…`	One-click unsubscribe (any bad link is friendly)
`/archive/{week}`	Web copy of a sent issue; unsent weeks show the sample
`/api/health`	Is it up, which keys are set (names only)
`/api/cron/*`	ingest, select, reminder, send, voice: locked with the cron secret
`/api/telegram/webhook`	Telegram taps arrive here (secret required)
`/api/resend/webhook`	Bounces, complaints, opens (signature required)

THREE ONE-LINERS TO MEMORISE

1
It never sends alone.
Two taps from Shreya, a lock in the code, and no send button on the dashboard.

2
Gemini proposes. Code verifies. She decides.
Every rule is checked in code; the final judgment stays Shreya's.

3
Every drop has a reason.
Any article, kept or dropped, shows why in the All articles tab.

> *If asked "how do you know it works?": "I tested the safety rules with failing cases, not just the happy path: it refuses to send unconfirmed, catches near-duplicates, switches bad addresses off, and I audited the live site end to end."*